of the Indian Constitution empowered parliament to legislate all aspects of foreign affairs including implementation of international treaties, agreements and conventions.

In practice, however, the conduct of Indian foreign policy rests with the executive branch of government even as the Ministry of External Affairs is subject to parliamentary oversight like all government ministries. Parliamentary oversight is exercised through discussions and debates on the floor, as well as through question hour – the time set aside during parliament's deliberations for MPs to question ministers on their department's performance. Parliamentary Committees on External Affairs and Defence also act as instruments of parliamentary oversight.

The parliament discusses and approves bills introduced by the Ministry of External Affairs, asks questions on issues and also studies and discusses the annual report of the Ministry of External Affairs before approving it. Officials of the Ministry of External Affairs say that a lot of their time is taken up in preparing answers to questions raised by parliamentarians during the period when parliament is in session. Questions are sometimes tied to a media report (say, on Indian hostages in Iraq) while on other occasions relate to the government's policy towards a certain country or specific international issue.

Those who criticize parliamentary oversight note that in almost every democracy most politicians are oriented towards domestic issues and they have relatively little knowledge or awareness of foreign affairs. As a result, parliamentary debates on foreign policy are not always based on hard facts or an objective assessment of reality. They often become an opportunity for the opposition to criticize the government or the party in power.

One way of building up a group of politicians who are knowledgeable about and have experience of foreign policy is through the committee system. There are two committees for external affairs, the consultative committee and the standing committee.